

ANTH270/370 Anthropology of Childhood

Illinois Wesleyan University, Fall 2016

MWF 1:00 — 1:50 p.m. SFH 204

Instructor: Kirill Maslinsky, CLA 246
Contacts: Office: 556-3653, kmaslins@iwu.edu
Office hours: Mon 11–12 a.m., Wed: 2–4 p.m., Fri: 10–12 a.m. or by appointment

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Last fifty years have witnessed the rising academic interest to childhood in social sciences and humanities. Childhood seems worth of academic investment either as a potential target for solving the most pressing social problems of the modern world or as a peculiar social phenomenon that may serve as a key to understanding distinct features of human cultures as well as of the humanity at large. Anthropology plays a special part in the assembly of disciplines covered by the broad term ‘Childhood studies’. The anthropologists’ constant endeavor to show the diversity of childhood experience found throughout the world’s cultures is their say against imposing peculiarities of Western culture as global normative views of what childhood is or should be.

The ultimate goal of this course is to help students understand childhood in their own culture as a cultural construction by analysing different historical, ethnic and social varieties of childhood experience. By giving an anthropological perspective on the topics in child development, childrearing practices, family life, schooling, work and play we will seek to make explicit some of those cultural assumptions, values and expectations that together constitute the notion of childhood. During the course we will discuss different cultures and historical periods, but one particular recurring case will be Russian childhood of the Soviet era. The course is designed to encompass various sources that may serve as data for studying childhood ranging from ethnographic fieldwork to the content analysis of parenting manuals. Students at 300-level will be offered opportunity to choose from the range of the discussed methods of study in anthropology of childhood for their final research paper.

The course offers general education credit in ANALYSIS OF VALUES and bears GLOBAL DIVERSITY flag.

REQUIREMENTS

ATTENDANCE. I expect students to attend classes faithfully and arrive to class on time. If you must miss class for any reason other than illness, please notify me as early as possible so that we can make appropriate arrangements. More than two unexcused absences during the course will negatively affect your grade. You are required to attend one film showing during the course — “The scarecrow” directed by Rolan Bykov. Missing this showing will count as an unexcused absence. See the semester schedule for the date.

PARTICIPATION. Since the course is centered on interactive lectures and class discussions, active participation is crucial to success in this course. I expect that a successful student will regularly and voluntarily contribute ideas and comments that are relevant and not obvious without being domineering. Adequate performance in group assignments both in and out of class is an essential aspect of your participation. Creative ideas are very valued. Failing to speak in class or distracting from productive class discussion will have negative impact on your participation grade.

REQUIRED TEXTS. All the texts assigned for reading are available to you in electronic form. Papers and book excerpts are posted on the course website on [Moodle](#). If an assigned paper or book is missing on Moodle, this means that it is either publicly available online or available to you through the Ames library. It is *your* responsibility to locate and download such resources. All assigned material should be read *before* the class under which it is listed in the syllabus.

ASSIGNMENTS AND EXAMS. Participation in group discussion, short written essays, creative group projects, midterm exam, final exam and a personal project (presentation for 200-level and research paper for 300-level student) will be part of your grade. Students at the 300 level will be required to collect data and write a 10–12 pages final research paper along with short presentation of their research in class in TED format. Requirements for the research paper and for the TED presentation will be distributed separately.

When an assignment type is stated as ‘short essay’ that refers to an expected mean text length of couple of pages. I do not provide required length in words because I will grade the content and clarity of presentation of the text, and not its length. Nevertheless, writing significantly less or more than the expected mean of a few pages will reduce the chance of either content or clarity to be evaluated favorably.

Written exams (midterm and final) will cover the content of the assigned reading material and will combine multiple choice test with short essay questions.

I expect you to complete all assignments on time. Assignments should be handed in by the start of the class period on the due date indicated in the semester schedule. Assignments turned in late will lose 20% of its grade value for each day after the deadline. Please note, that being absent on a day an assignment is due does not absolve you from having to turn in the assignment on that date.

ACADEMIC HONESTY. Plagiarism and cheating will not be tolerated in this course. Plagiarism is defined as presenting others’ words and ideas as your own without proper credit or reference. Any discovered instance of cheating on assignments and exams or plagiarism in written or orally presented work will result in automatic “F” for the assignment. You will not be permitted to redo the assignment for credit.

GRADING

GRADING CRITERIA FOR 200 LEVEL

Class participation	30	10%
Short essays (6 @ 10 pts.)	60	20%
Creative group projects (2 @ 20 pts.)	40	13%
Group discussion projects (2 @ 10 pts.)	20	7%
Reading quiz (3 @ 10 pts.)	30	10%
Midterm exam	30	10%
Final exam	30	10%
Personal project presentation	30	10%
Personal project paper	30	10%
<i>Course total</i>	300	

GRADING CRITERIA FOR 300 LEVEL

Class participation	30	10%
Short essays (6 @ 10 pts.)	60	20%
Creative group projects (2 @ 20 pts.)	40	13%
Group discussion projects (2 @ 10 pts.)	20	7%
Reading quiz (3 @ 10 pts.)	30	10%
Midterm exam	30	10%
Final exam	30	10%
Research project presentation	10	3%
Research project paper	50	17%
<i>Course total</i>	300	

GRADING SCALE

A+ = 100 – 98% ; A = 97 – 94% ; A- = 93 – 90% ; B+ = 89 – 88% ; B = 87 – 84% ; B- = 83 – 80% ; C+ = 79 – 78% ; C = 77 – 74% ; C- = 73 – 70% ; D = 69 – 60% ; F ≤ 59%.

SEMESTER SCHEDULE*

*I reserve the right to change any elements of this syllabus. Please check your e-mail regularly for any changes in assignments. If you miss class, it is *your* responsibility to get an updated assignment.

WEEK #1_____CONTEXTUALIZING AGE

M 08/29 Introduction. *Childhood: an interactive definition.*

ASSIGNMENT: Write your own definition of childhood based on class discussion. DUE BY: W 08/31.

W 08/31 *The beginning of Childhood.* Data sources and research methods: Ethnography.

ASSIGNMENT: Short essay developing an argument formulated in a group discussion in class. DUE BY: F 09/02.

F 09/02 Lecture: *The story of “Coming of Age”: Margaret Mead and Anthropology of Childhood.*
ASSIGNMENT: Choose one of the articles for reading and discussion, see details under M 09/07. If you miss class on Friday, it is your responsibility to find out which group you are in.

WEEK #2_____MATERIAL WORLD OF CHILDHOOD

W 09/07 *An old discussion: Swaddling and Russian character.*
READING: Mead 1951; On Friday, 09/02 the class will be split into groups, each group will be assigned to read one of the following papers: Benedict 1949; Gorer 1949; Mead 1954. In class your group will present and defend arguments of the assigned paper.

F 09/09 Data sources and research methods: Children’s artifacts and family portraits.
READING: K. L. F. Calvert 1992, Ch. 1, pp. 19–38 Optional for presentation (extra credit available, please volunteer): K. Calvert 1982.
ASSIGNMENT: Short essay on a toy as a material and cultural object. DUE BY: 09/12.

WEEK #3_____WORK AND PLAY

M 09/12 *Play and toys.*
READING: Baxter 2005, Ch. 4, pp. 39–50. SHORT ESSAY ON A TOY is due.

W 09/14 *Chores and labor.*
READING: Lancy 2015, Ch. 7, pp. 254–272, pp. 278–283.

F 09/16 Lecture: *Mother–Child play: questioning universals of child development.*
READING: Lancy 2007.

WEEK #4_____COGNITIVE DEVELOPMENT AND LANGUAGE SOCIALIZATION

M 09/19 Lecture: *Ethnography of language socialization.* Baby-talk. Language and cognitive development. Cultural assumptions of psychological tests.
READING: Harkness and Super 1977
ASSIGNMENT: Creative group project: Election campaign poster and speech on language policy. Details will be discussed in class.

W 09/21 *Questions we ask our children.* Community expectations and child narratives.
READING: Heath 1982 or Heath 1983, pp. 296–310. Data sources and research methods: Sociolinguistics. DUE BY: F 09/23.

F 09/23 *Creative group project: Election campaign poster and speech on language policy.*

WEEK #5_____CHILDREARING. DISCIPLINARY PRACTICES

M 09/26 Lecture: *Cross-cultural analysis of discipline.* Functionalism in anthropology.
READING: Ember and Ember 2005. Data sources and research methods: Regression analysis.
ASSIGNMENT: Short essay — a research proposal for a quantitative cross-cultural study. DUE BY: M 10/03.

W 09/28 *Disciplinary practices in family and at school.* Comparative case: US and USSR.
READING: Bronfenbrenner and Condry Jr 1970, pp. 7–15, 51–69.
ASSIGNMENT: Prepare for the discussion on Friday. Class will be split into groups to defend opposing viewpoints, and discussion leaders will be assigned. DUE BY: F 09/30.

F 09/30 *Discussion: discipline and abuse.* The notion of cultural relativity and its limits.
READING: Montgomery 2008, Ch. 6, pp. 156–180.

WEEK #6 _____ INSTITUTIONS OF CHILDHOOD

M 10/03 Lecture: *Norms-imposing institutions: Pediatrics, Pedagogy, School.* Mass schooling and the development of age grading.
READING: Lasseonde 2013. A RESEARCH PROPOSAL ESSAY is due.

W 10/05 *Parenting manuals.* Data sources and research methods: Content analysis.
READING: Spock 1976, Ch. 1, pp. 1–18.
ASSIGNMENT: Content analysis task of a text on parenting will be assigned to each student. Details will be discussed in class. If you miss class, it is *your* responsibility to reach me to get your assignment. DUE BY: M 10/24.

F 10/07 *Children's literature. Picture books.*

WEEK #7 _____ UNIVERSALS AND VARIABILITY OF CHILDHOOD

M 10/10 *Universals of child rearing.*
READING: Quinn 2005.

W 10/12 MIDTERM EXAM.

WEEK #8 _____ INVENTION OF MODERN CHILDHOOD

M 10/17 *Modern childhood values: The emergence of 'precious child'.*
READING: Zelizer 1985, Ch. 2, pp. 56–73.
ASSIGNMENT: Think of a topic for your personal project. Students at 200 level will be required to collect data for a presentation and short paper on representation of childhood in visual media "Iconography of childhood". Students at 300 level students are required to write and present in class a research paper on any topic in anthropology of childhood. Details will be discussed in class..

W 10/19 *Child as a consumer.*
ASSIGNMENT: Short essay based on observation of family consumer behavior. DUE BY: F 10/21.

F 10/21 *Variability of modern childhood.* Parenting ethnotheories in Western cultures.
READING: Harkness and Super 2006. ESSAY ON A CONSUMER BEHAVIOR is due.

WEEK #9_____CHILDREN'S GEOGRAPHIES

- M 10/24 Lecture: *Children's space and time. Playing spaces.*
READING: Karsten 2005.
- W 10/26 *Mapping children's play.* Data sources and research methods: Maps.
ASSIGNMENT: Short essay: annotate your map with an ethnographic commentary.
- F 10/28 *Childhood memories.* Fieldwork seminar. Data sources and research methods: Interview.
ANNOTATED MAP is due.

WEEK #10_____CHILDREN'S FOLKLORE

- M 10/31 Lecture: *Genres of children's folklore.* Plot structure analysis.
READING: Tucker 2012. APPROVED TOPIC FOR PERSONAL PROJECTS FOR 200 LEVEL STUDENTS is due.
- W 11/02 *Fear in children's folklore.* Russian children's horror stories. APPROVED TOPIC OF INDIVIDUAL RESEARCH PROJECT FOR 300-LEVEL STUDENTS is due.
ASSIGNMENT: For 300-level students: Prepare an annotated bibliography of secondary literature on your research topic (3–5 items). DUE BY: W 11/09.
- F 11/04 *Death in children's folklore.* Russian children's sadistic poems.

WEEK #11_____EMOTIONS

- M 11/07 Lecture: *History of childhood emotions: shame.*
READING: Matt 2014.
ASSIGNMENT: For 200-level students: collect data and prepare a presentation on iconography of happy childhood. Details will be discussed in class. DUE BY: F 11/11.
- W 11/09 *History of childhood emotions: happiness.*
READING: Lancy 2010. *Iconography of happy childhood.* Soviet case: "Thank you, dear comrade Stalin" ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHIES FOR 300-LEVEL STUDENTS is due.
ASSIGNMENT: For 300-level students: Decide on data sources and methods of analysis for your final research paper. Prepare 1 page description of your data and methods. DUE BY: M 11/14.
- F 11/11 PRESENTATION ON ICONOGRAPHY OF CHILDHOOD FOR 200-LEVEL STUDENTS is due.

WEEK #12_____ADOLESCENCE

- M 11/14 *End of childhood? Rites of passage. Initiation.*
READING: Montgomery 2008, Ch. 8, pp. 212–232. FOR 300-LEVEL STUDENTS: DESCRIPTION OF YOUR DATA AND METHODS is due.
ASSIGNMENT: For 300-level students: Prepare a draft of your final research paper. DUE BY: M 11/28.
- W 11/16 *End of childhood? Adolescent sexuality.*
READING: Kelly 2007, pp. 570–590.
- F 11/18 *End of childhood? Resistance to authority and school.*
READING: Kipnis 2001.

WEEK #13_____SOVIET CHILDHOOD UNMASKED

- Su 20/11 *Viewing of a film "Scarecrow" directed by R. Bykov. Place and time TBA.*
M 21/11 *Film discussion: Scarecrow by R. Bykov*

WEEK #14_____MODELS OF CHILDHOOD

- M 11/28 *Lecture: Social class and American childhood: concerted cultivation vs. natural growth.*
READING: Lareau 2011, any one of the chapters: 3–12. FOR 300-LEVEL STUDENTS: DRAFT OF YOUR FINAL RESEARCH PAPER is due.
ASSIGNMENT: Creative group project: a screenplay for an ethnographic film on childhood, representing one main child character (fictional) of the subculture and time period of your choice. Each member of the group will be assigned an aspect of a childhood that s/he is responsible to portray in the screenplay, e.g. chores, discipline, schooling etc. The final project will be graded on all aspects separately so that each student will receive own grade.
W 11/30 *Data sources and research methods: Ethnographic film.*
F 12/02 *Modelling childhood. GROUP PROJECT: SCREENPLAY FOR AN ETHNOGRAPHIC FILM ON CHILDHOOD is due.*
ASSIGNMENT: For 300-level students: prepare a 5-minute presentation of your final research project. DUE BY: M 12/05

WEEK #15_____RESEARCH PRESENTATIONS

- M 12/05 *Mini-conference in TED format. Part 1.*
PRESENTATION ON PERSONAL RESEARCH PROJECT FOR 300-LEVEL STUDENTS is due.
W 12/07 *Mini-conference in TED format. Part 2.*
F 12/09 *Mini-conference in TED format. Part 3.*
FINAL RESEARCH PAPER FOR 300-LEVEL STUDENTS AND PERSONAL PROJECT PAPER FOR 200-LEVEL STUDENTS is due.

WEEK #16_____EXAM WEEK

- F 12/16 *FINAL EXAM: 8–10 a.m.*

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- Baxter, Jane Eva (2005). *The archaeology of childhood: children, gender, and material culture*. Rowman Altamira.
Benedict, Ruth (1949). "Child rearing in certain European countries." In: *American Journal of Orthopsychiatry* 19.2, pp. 342–350.
Bronfenbrenner, Urie and John C Condry Jr (1970). *Two worlds of childhood: US and USSR*. New York: Russell Sage Foundation.
Calvert, Karin (1982). "Children in American Family Portraiture, 1670 to 1810." In: *The William and Mary Quarterly: A Magazine of Early American History and Culture*, pp. 87–113.
Calvert, Karin Lee Fishbeck (1992). *Children in the house: The material culture of early childhood, 1600-1900*. Northeastern University Press.

- Ember, Carol R and Melvin Ember (2005). "Explaining Corporal Punishment of Children: A Cross-Cultural Study." In: *American Anthropologist* 107.4, pp. 609–619.
- Gorer, Geoffrey (1949). "Some aspects of the psychology of the people of Great Russia." In: *American Slavic and East European Review* 8.3, pp. 155–166.
- Harkness, Sara and Charles M Super (1977). "Why African children are so hard to test." In: *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences* 285.1, pp. 326–331.
- Harkness, Sara and Charles M Super (2006). "Themes and variations: Parental ethnotheories in Western cultures." In: *Parenting beliefs, behaviors, and parent-child relations: A cross-cultural perspective*, pp. 61–79.
- Heath, Shirley Brice (1982). "Questioning at home and at school: A comparative study." In: *Doing the ethnography of schooling: Educational anthropology in action*, pp. 102–131.
- Heath, Shirley Brice (1983). *Ways with words: Language, life and work in communities and classrooms*. Cambridge University Press.
- Karsten, Lia (2005). "It all used to be better? Different generations on continuity and change in urban children's daily use of space." In: *Children's Geographies* 3.3, pp. 275–290.
- Kelly, Catriona (2007). *Children's world: growing up in Russia, 1890–1991*. Yale University Press.
- Kipnis, Andrew (2001). "Articulating school countercultures." In: *Anthropology & education quarterly* 32.4, pp. 472–492.
- Lancy, David F (2007). "Accounting for variability in mother–child play." In: *American Anthropologist* 109.2, pp. 273–284.
- Lancy, David F (2010). *What price happiness?* URL: <https://www.psychologytoday.com/blog/benign-neglect/201011/what-price-happiness> (visited on 08/23/2016).
- Lancy, David F (2015). *The anthropology of childhood: Cherubs, chattel, changelings*. 2nd ed. Cambridge University Press.
- Lareau, Annette (2011). *Unequal childhoods: Class, race, and family life*. Univ of California Press.
- Lassonde, S (2013). "Age, schooling, and development." In: *The Routledge History of Childhood in the Western World*. Ed. by Paula S. Fass. London: Routledge, pp. 211–228.
- Matt, Susan (2014). "Recovering the invisible. Methods for the historical study of the emotions." In: *Doing Emotions History*. Ed. by Peter N. Stearns Susan J. Matt. Urbana: University of Illinois press, pp. 41–53.
- Mead, Margaret (1951). "What makes the Soviet character." In: *Natural History Magazine* 51, pp. 296–303, 336.
- Mead, Margaret (1954). "The swaddling hypothesis: its reception." In: *American Anthropologist* 56.3, pp. 395–409.
- Montgomery, Heather (2008). *An introduction to childhood: Anthropological perspectives on children's lives*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Quinn, Naomi (2005). "Universals of child rearing." In: *Anthropological Theory* 5.4, pp. 477–516.
- Spock, Benjamin (1976). *Baby and child care*. New York: Pocket Books.
- Tucker, Elisabeth (2012). "Tales and Legends." In: *Children's folklore: A sourcebook*. Ed. by Brian Sutton-Smith et al. Routledge, pp. 193–212.
- Zelizer, Viviana A Rotman (1985). *Pricing the priceless child: The changing social value of children*. Princeton University Press.